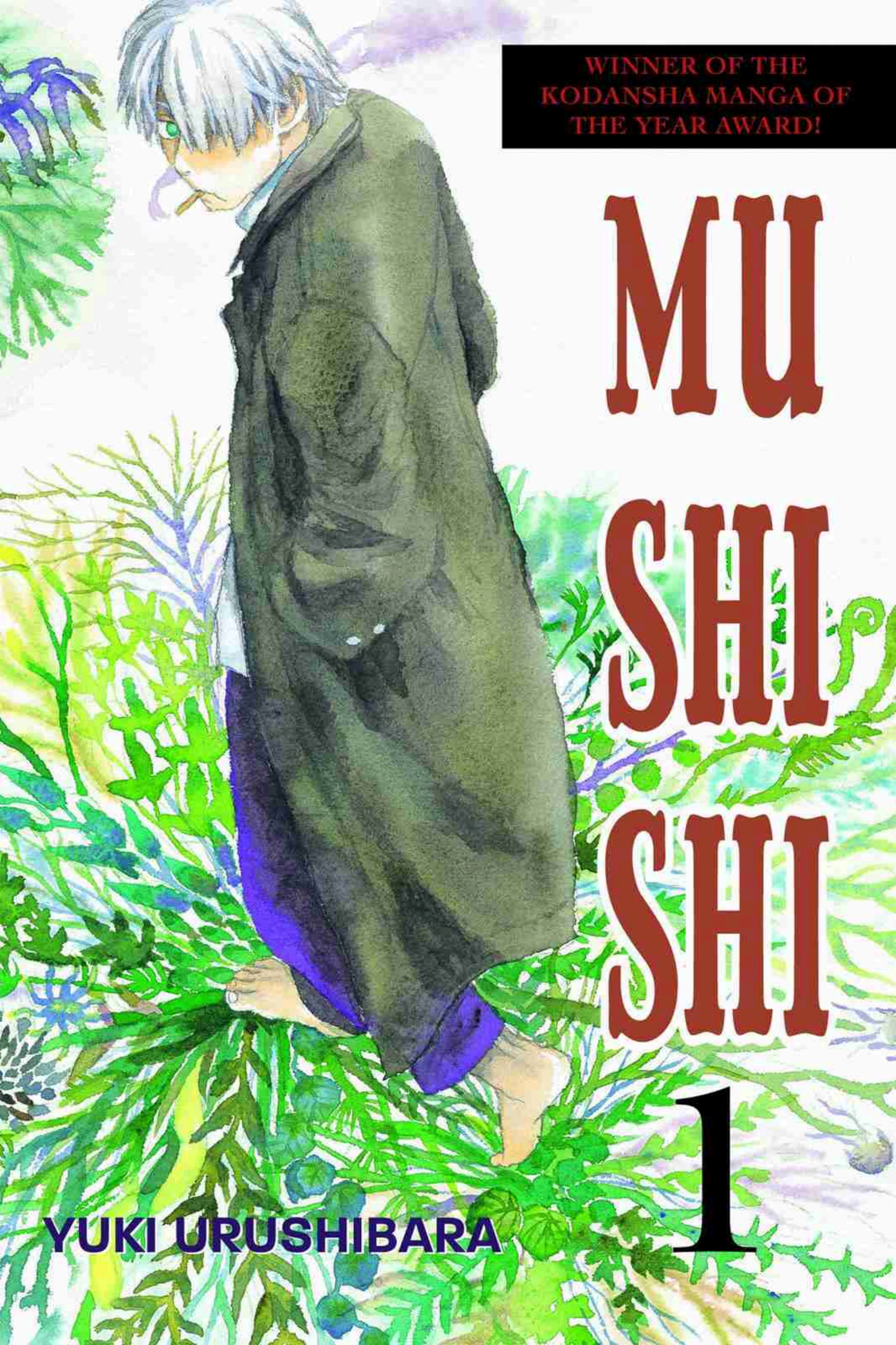
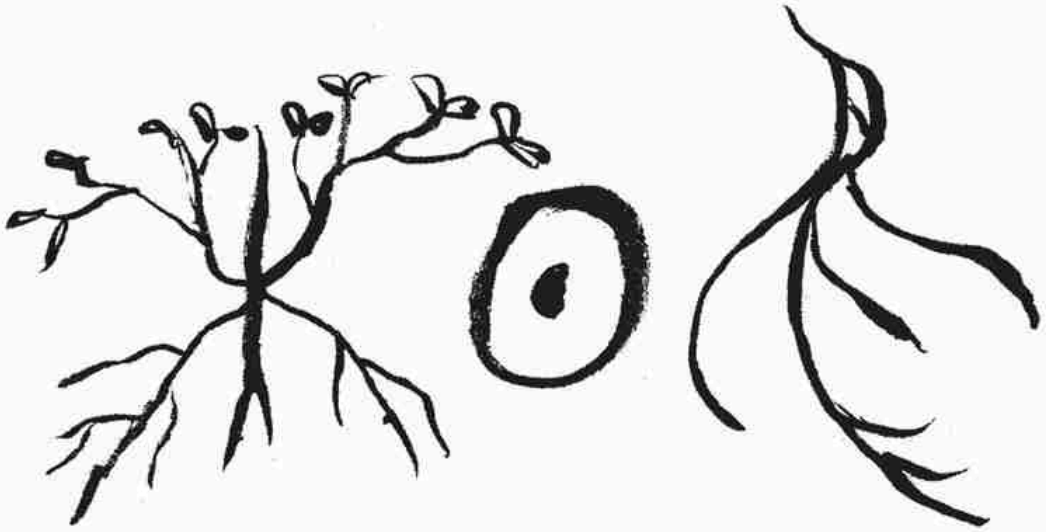

WINNER OF THE KODANSHA MANGA OF THE YEAR AWARD!
MUSHISHI
1
YUKI URUSHIBARA

About Mushi

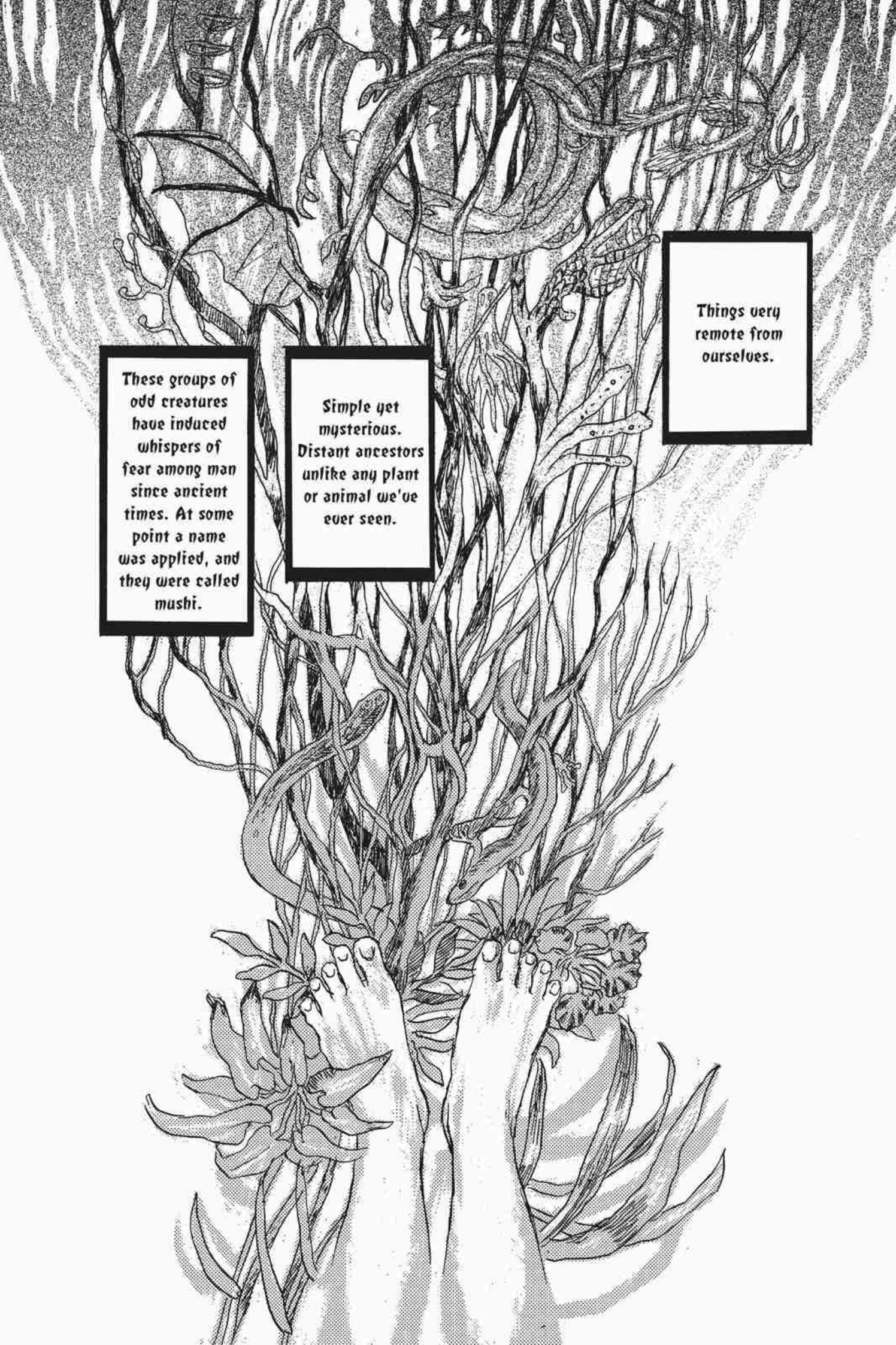
The kanji for *mushi* is made up of three kanji meaning bug (also called *mushi*) put together. The kanji can be used interchangeably for insect, but they can easily take on other meanings. In CLAMP's *xxxHolic,* the kanji was introduced as the name for a type of magical vermin.

Mushishi can be translated as "*mushi* master." Ginko is a man who made a study of *mushi* and seems to have learned to control some through his own senses and others through medicines, remedies, or just a knowledge of their nature. Ginko probably learned his craft from other older *mushishi* who wander Japan.



Contents

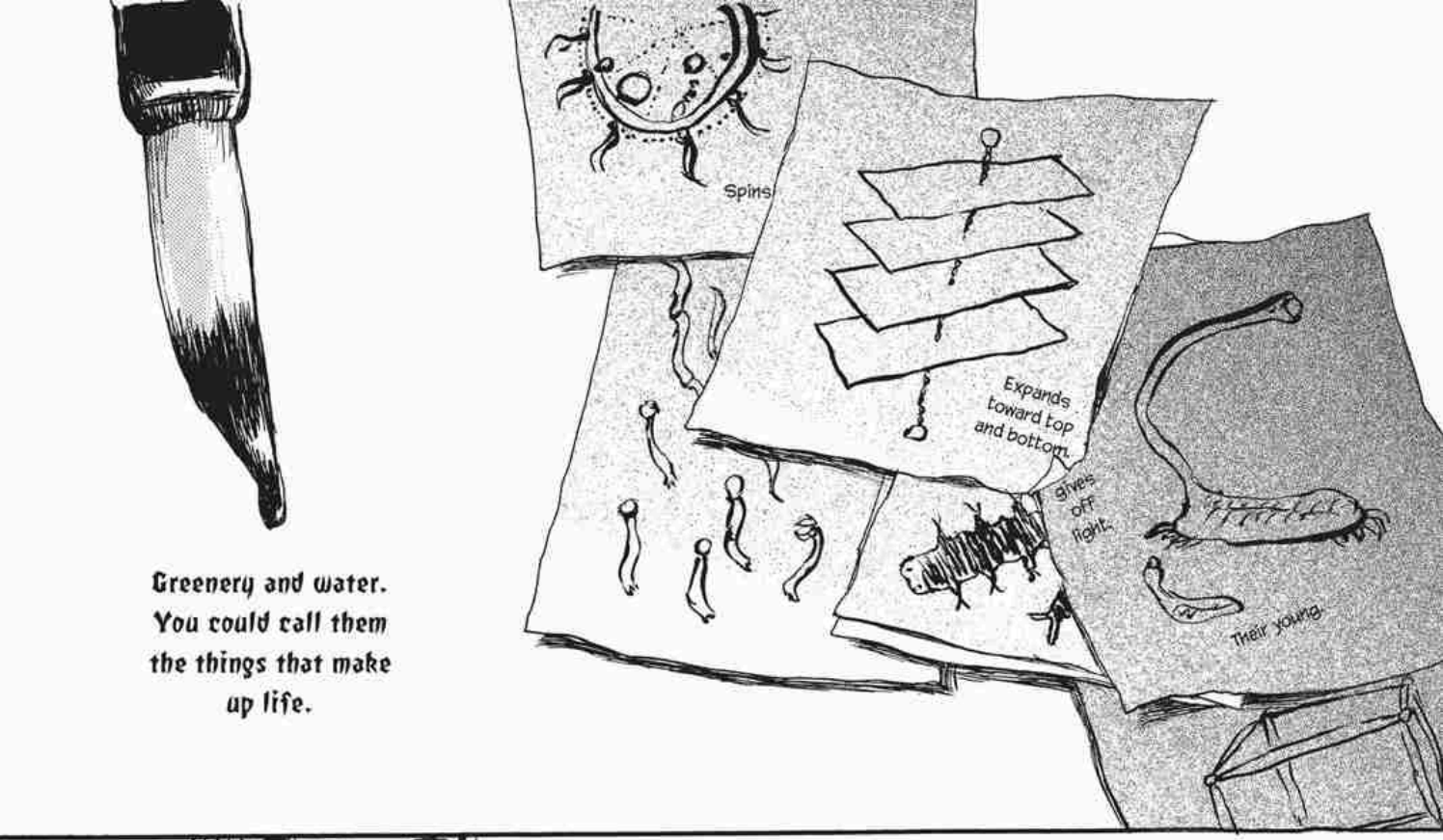
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These groups of odd creatures have induced whispers of fear among man since ancient times. At some point a name was applied, and they were called mushi.
Simple yet mysterious. Distant ancestors unlike any plant or animal we've ever seen.
Things very remote from ourselves.


The Green Gathering


Somebody's coming.
WHOOSH
Somebody weird is coming here.
Somebody's coming.
SHF

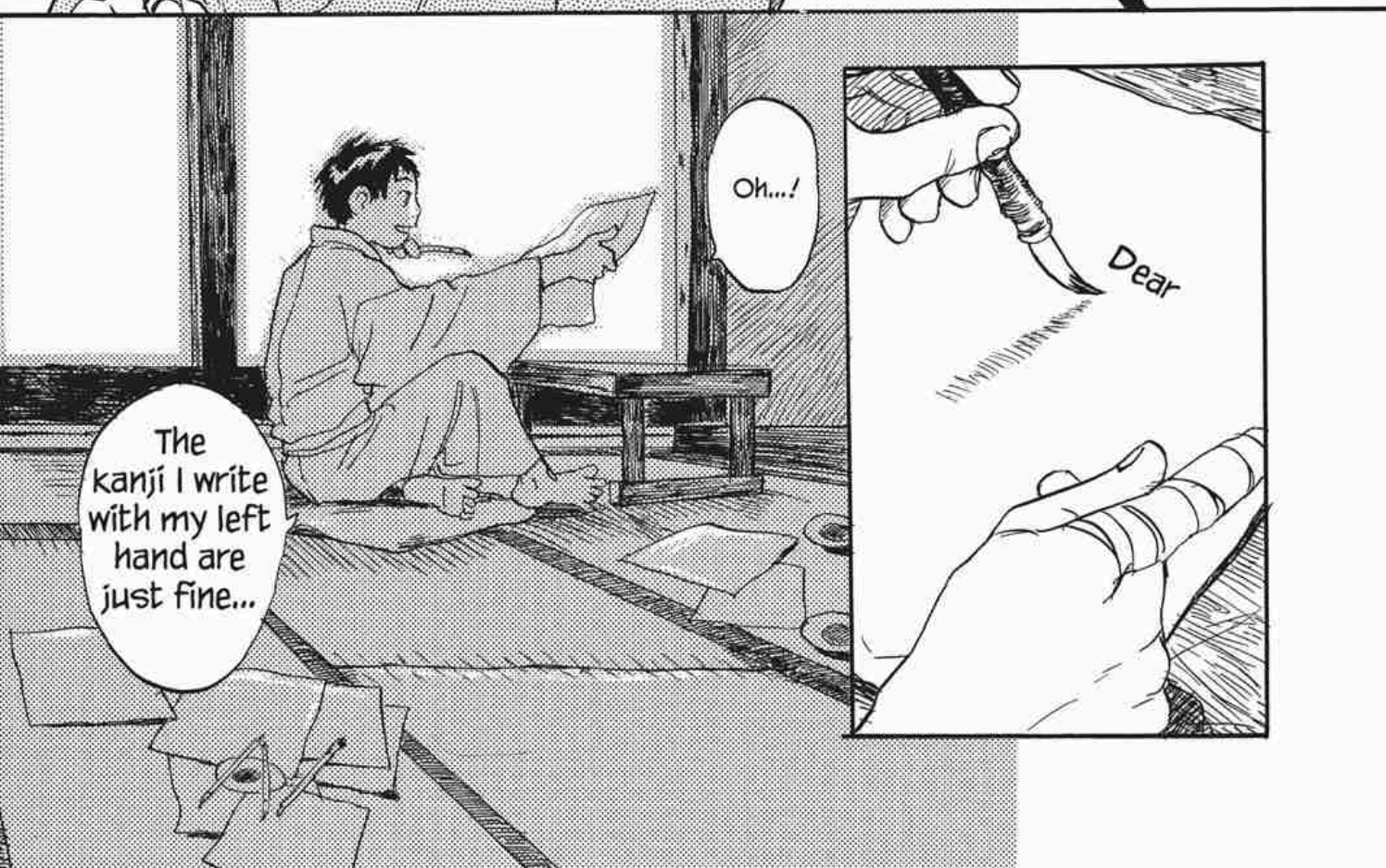

.....
Something was there, huh?
FLAP
A monkey, maybe?
FLAP
But...
The greenery here is so bright, it's kind of bizarre.
Nature...



Greenery and water. You could call them the things that make up life.

...are few.

The humans who have made it their study...




Let's see...
The rays of sunlight gradually cool as the trees burst with green. The birds...
SLISS
SLISS
I was originally left-handed anyway, this makes writing so much easier.
MLUUG
!!
The sunlight
The trees burst
PICHICHICHI
TWIK
PIIIIICHICHICHICHI
.....


Geez!!
This'll take care of these guys.
I should have known.
It's happened!
Dammit.
SHEEN
SHEEN
GWIP
GWIP
These kanji were originally pictures.
Logo-graphs are what they call them.
Hey! Come here, "bird"!
Don't you dare fly outside!!
TMP
TMP
TMP
TMP


SWSS
.....
What's this thing?
PICHICHI
SHUM
GLMP
Ink...?
D-
Did you see it...?
HAHH
HAHH
Yeah.
I saw it go right into my hand.
So this would be... maybe...
Ah!


Are you...
Shinra Iorui-kun?
Eh?
Yeah...
Maybe you read the letter I sent you?
I wrote you back asking you not to bother.
Ah!
Then you're that mushishi.
Ginko... san?
There have been quite a few mushishi...
...who have wanted to investigate my case. I've refused all of them.
It was my grandmother's dying wish.
That I shouldn't spread knowledge of my nature. And... I should keep from awakening it as much as possible.


Just as you saw...
For as long as I can remember, anytime I drew something...
...even if it was a creature that doesn't exist, it took on life.
But my grandmother felt that my giving life to new life-forms was wrong.
That it would anger the eighty million gods.
She wrapped up my left hand and forbade me to use it.
Oh. Nothing happens when I draw with my right hand.
But recently I hurt my finger...
That's an amazing man-made creature.
That makes sense.
And that's how what you saw came about.


I don't want to be investigated!
He's pretty talkative.
Maybe that's why all of the mushishi know about him.
TSK!
HA!
I've seen some weird things moving by themselves, but...
I never thought something like that would start moving.
It surprised me, too.
An umbrella, a back scratcher... things like that.
Really? Like what?


You came all the way out here into the mountains, and that must have been a hard trip. Take it easy for tonight.
I'm not saying you have to leave here this minute.
Still...


Besides, it's been awhile since I've seen anyone.
I'd love to have someone to chat with.
かち KLINK
Here.
Really?
Normally I just drink here by myself.
It's a fruit wine that I make.
You live all alone out here in this secluded place?
Ever since my grandmother died four years ago.


...if he lived in a village and were to carelessly create one of those creatures...
It's true...
And she told me that I should never leave the house.
...would never turn out to be this quiet.
His life...
.....
Yes.
She always thought of me first.
They're something too upsetting for the human heart.
The things he creates...
Your grandmother sounds like she was a very wise woman.
...are a little too far beyond human knowledge.


Did you draw these?
!
Yes...
But...
.....
Here. Would you have a look at these?
?
Every time I find myself wondering just what the heck they are.
They were kind of fun to look at, so I thought I'd draw them and show them to my grandmother.
When I'm alone, sometimes these things appear.

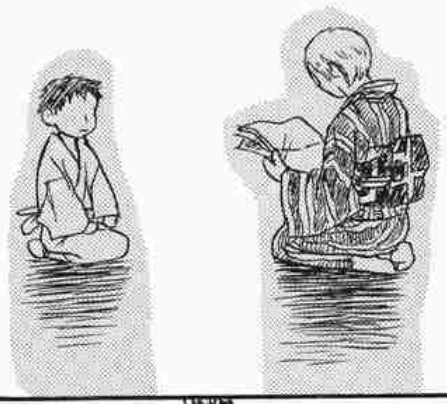
This makes me frightened. Very frightened.

These illusions are useless! Forget them!

It must be because you have that frightful power.

Why are you constantly having these dreams?!

But...



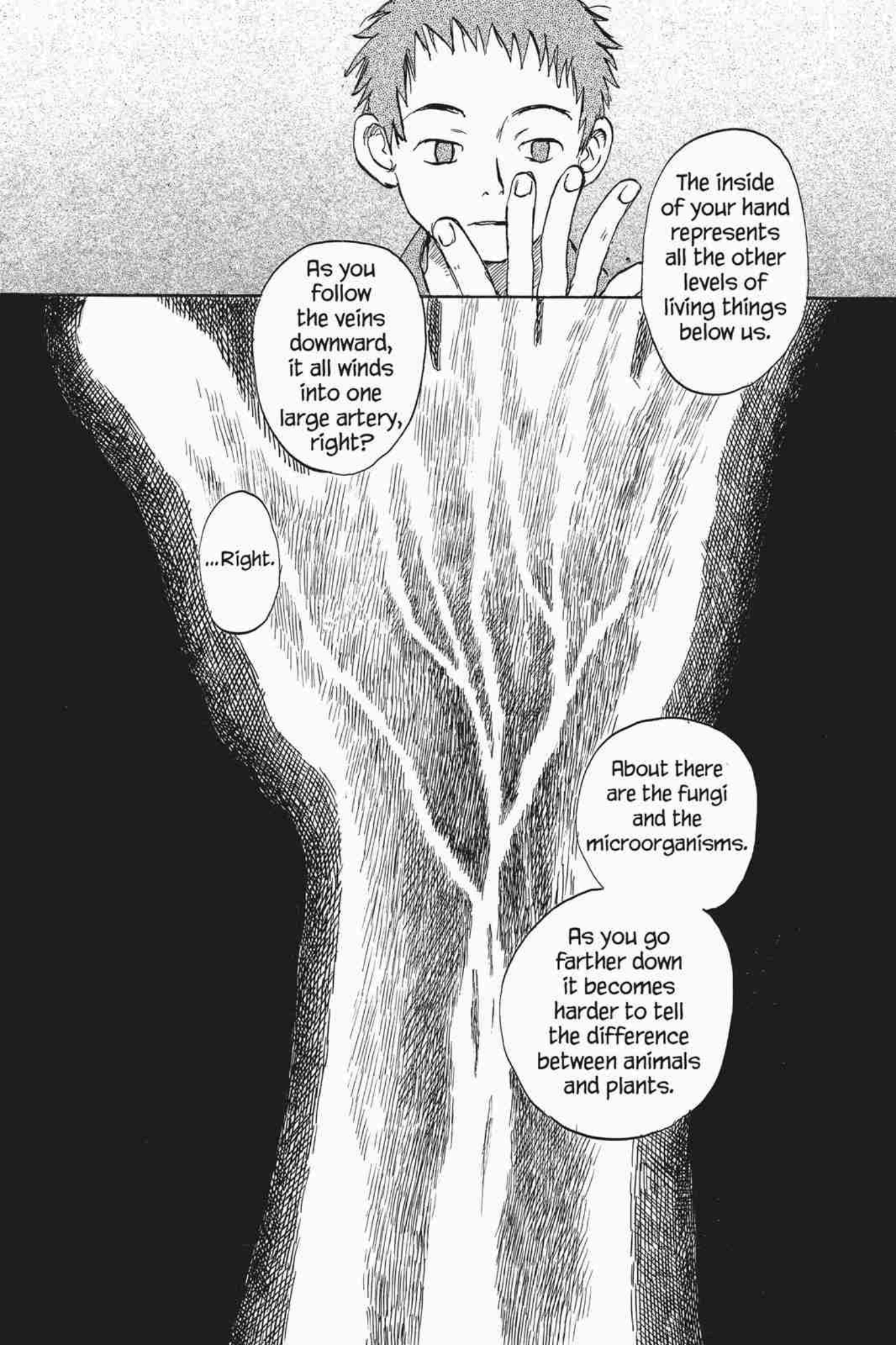


You pitiful soul.



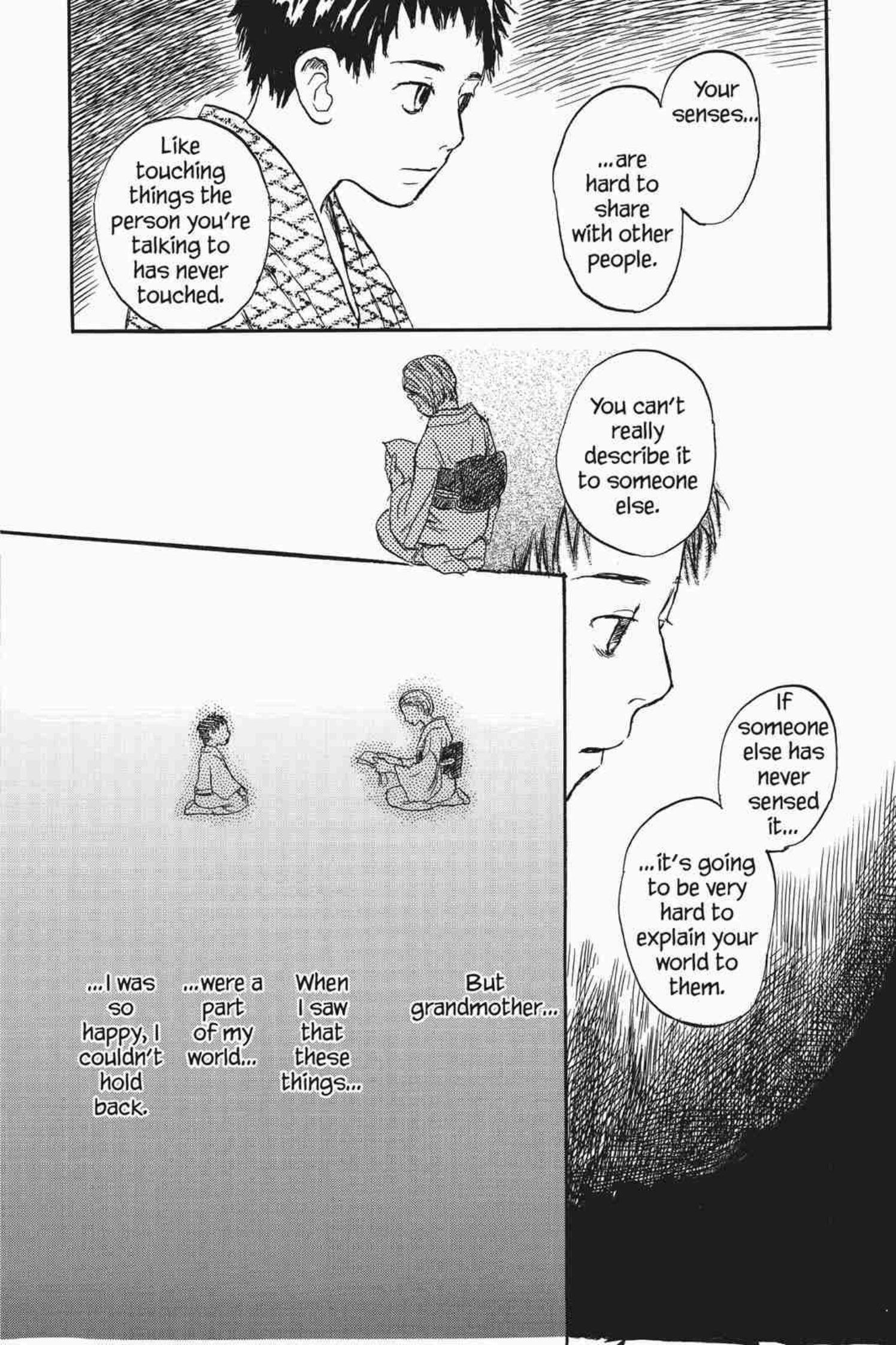



To put it roughly...
...if the four fingers on my hand represent all of the animals and my thumb represents present-day plants...
...then people would be here. On the very tip of the middle finger and the farthest place from the heart.
.....
Well, the reason could be that all of these are mushi.
Mushi?
Yeah.
You could probably trace insects and reptiles back to mushi.

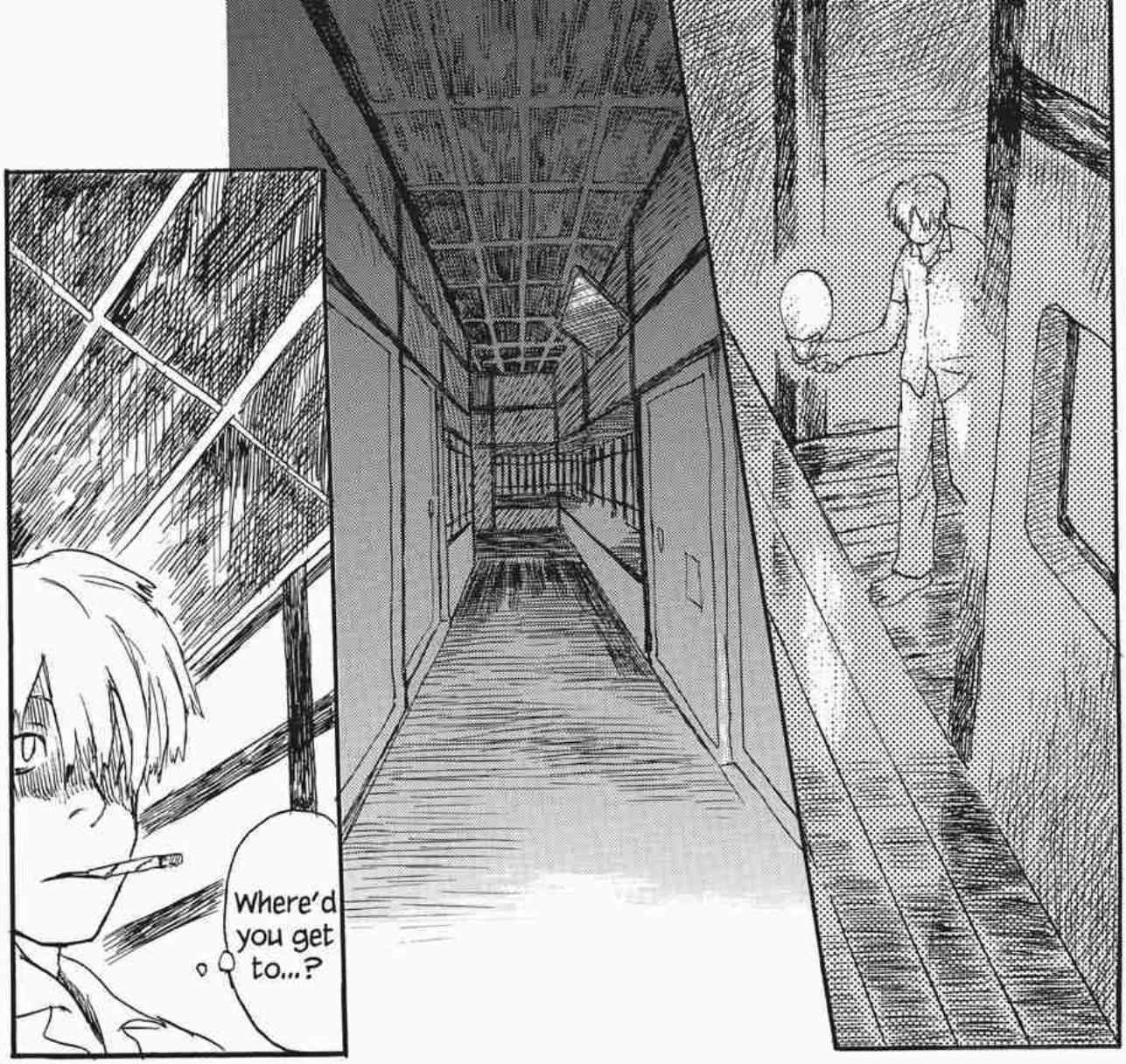

The inside of your hand represents all the other levels of living things below us.
As you follow the veins downward, it all winds into one large artery, right?
...Right.
About there are the fungi and the microorganisms.
As you go farther down it becomes harder to tell the difference between animals and plants.

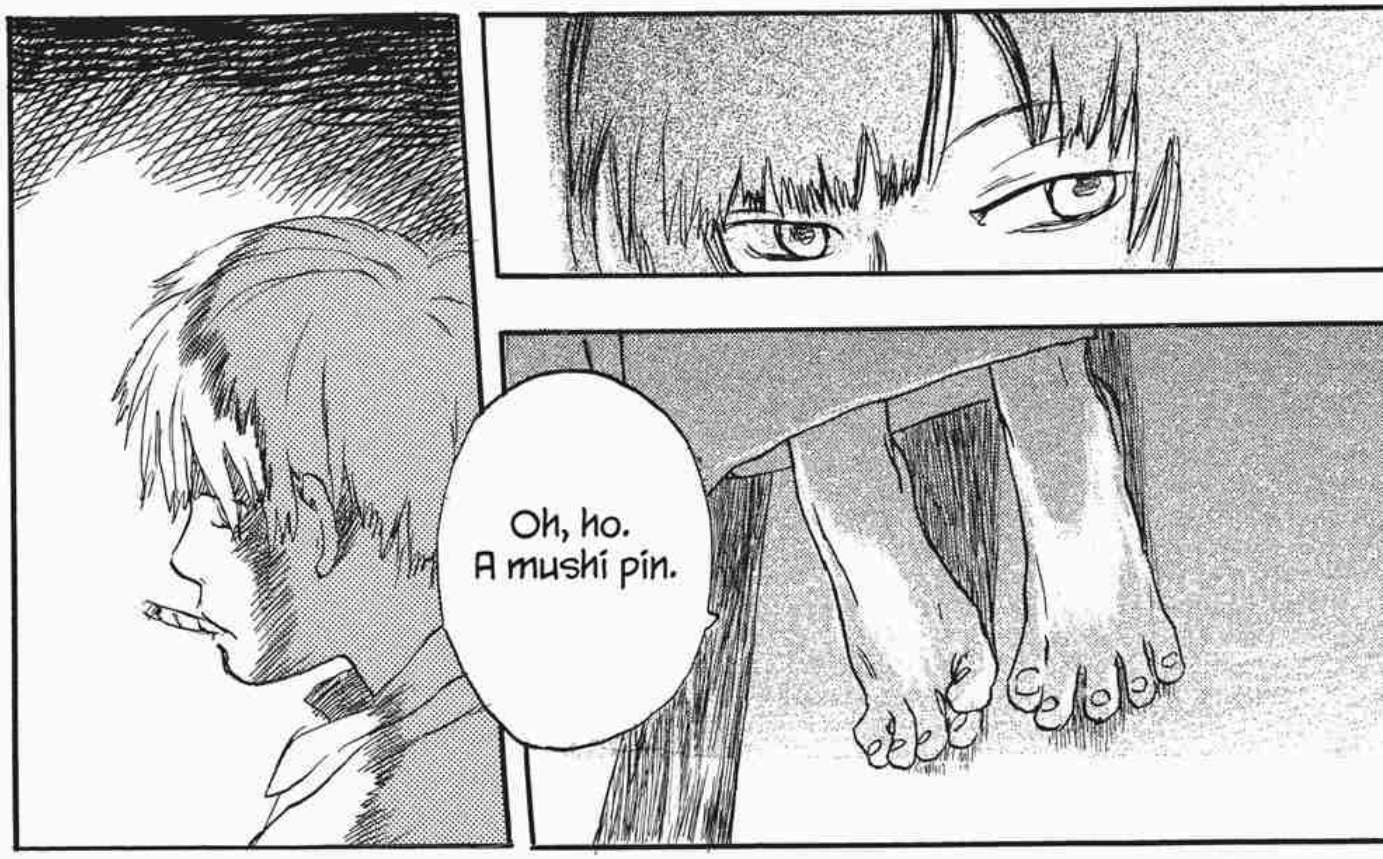

"Mushi." Some call them "Verdancy" or the "Green Things."
And if you get to just about this area, there's life there.
But there are things that are even earlier than that.
You can trace all the way down the arm and past the shoulder.
They're very close to the original forms of life.
It was after them that the life we see began to branch out.
And since they're so close, their shape and very existence is kind of vague.


Yes!
Some are transparent... kind of like ghosts.
They can go right through thin walls and paper doors.
Among the things that people call ghosts...
...some of them are really mushi.
There are some that can imitate human form.
.....
Your grandmother probably couldn't see them at all.
They're hard to sense, so when people do finally catch one, they attribute them to the "fairy" world.
Everyone more or less has the ability to sense them.
Nobody *can't* do it.
But...
Since nobody needs special abilities to see them, many people do see them.
But something triggers the sense that detects them, and some become able to control them...and others just forget them completely.


Your senses...
...are hard to share with other people.
Like touching things the person you're talking to has never touched.
You can't really describe it to someone else.
If someone else has never sensed it...
...it's going to be very hard to explain your world to them.
But grandmother...
When I saw that these things...
...were a part of my world...
...I was so happy, I couldn't hold back.


SHIF
Where's the privy...?
This house sure is big.
And pretty old.
Amazing he'd be here alone...
SHMM
Well, there're mushi here if nothing else.
Something moved.


Where'd you get to...?


Oh, ho. A mushi pin.


Do you skewer mushi with it to make decorations?
You're a suspicious-looking mushishi.
Suspicious?
Like a mushi has the right to talk.


FSSH
!
?!
GRNN
GRNN
Wh-What's going on? It's only smoke!
It's a mushi.
Just like you.
Cute little thing, isn't it?
It wraps up others of its kind and doesn't let go.


But it disappears pretty quickly.
ZLIP
Ah!
KA-TAK
HUP!
Oh, ho!
It may be broken in half, but this sake drinking bowl has a beautiful color.
Did you drink moon-viewing sake out of this?


Shut up and give it back to me!
You go barging into people's houses! Just get out of here!
"People's houses"? You think this is your house?
She's acting pretty high and mighty for a mushi!
Yes! It is!!
Hm?
.....
Oh...!
I get it!
So that's how it is!
You were originally a human, but you're one of those who managed to take on the life-form of a mushi!
But you're not completely a mushi, and that's why you're so weak.
!


And guess who you are...
Half of a broken green drinking bowl...
I'd say your name is Renzu.
If I were to figure out how you turned out this way...
Before I came here, I did some research on Shinra's blood relatives.
I've got a good idea of how to restore this bowl to its original form.
Do you want to hear it?


My grand-mother?!
You're saying she's still in this house?
Well, in a way, but she isn't here as a human.
She's somewhere between human and mushi.
...What... does that mean?
A mushi party.
That's what they call the phenomenon.
At times, the mushi imitate human form and invite guests to the party.


There, the people pass a drinking bowl around.
And they drink down the "sake" inside it.
The rules of life break down...
...and the humans begin to live as mushi.
My grandmother did?
Turned into that?
Yeah.
She left half of herself back there.
But one party was stopped in the middle.
And because of it, your grandmother never became a mushi.
When your grandmother went back home, she was a very different person than she was before.


Shinra...
The grandmother you knew was only half of her.
But that other half did much the same...
She watched over this house ever since the day you were born.
But...
I never noticed anything!
She wasn't a real mushi, so you couldn't see her.
But if you were to use your power...
...you could turn your grandmother completely into a mushi.
If you do it, she'll never return to being human, but...

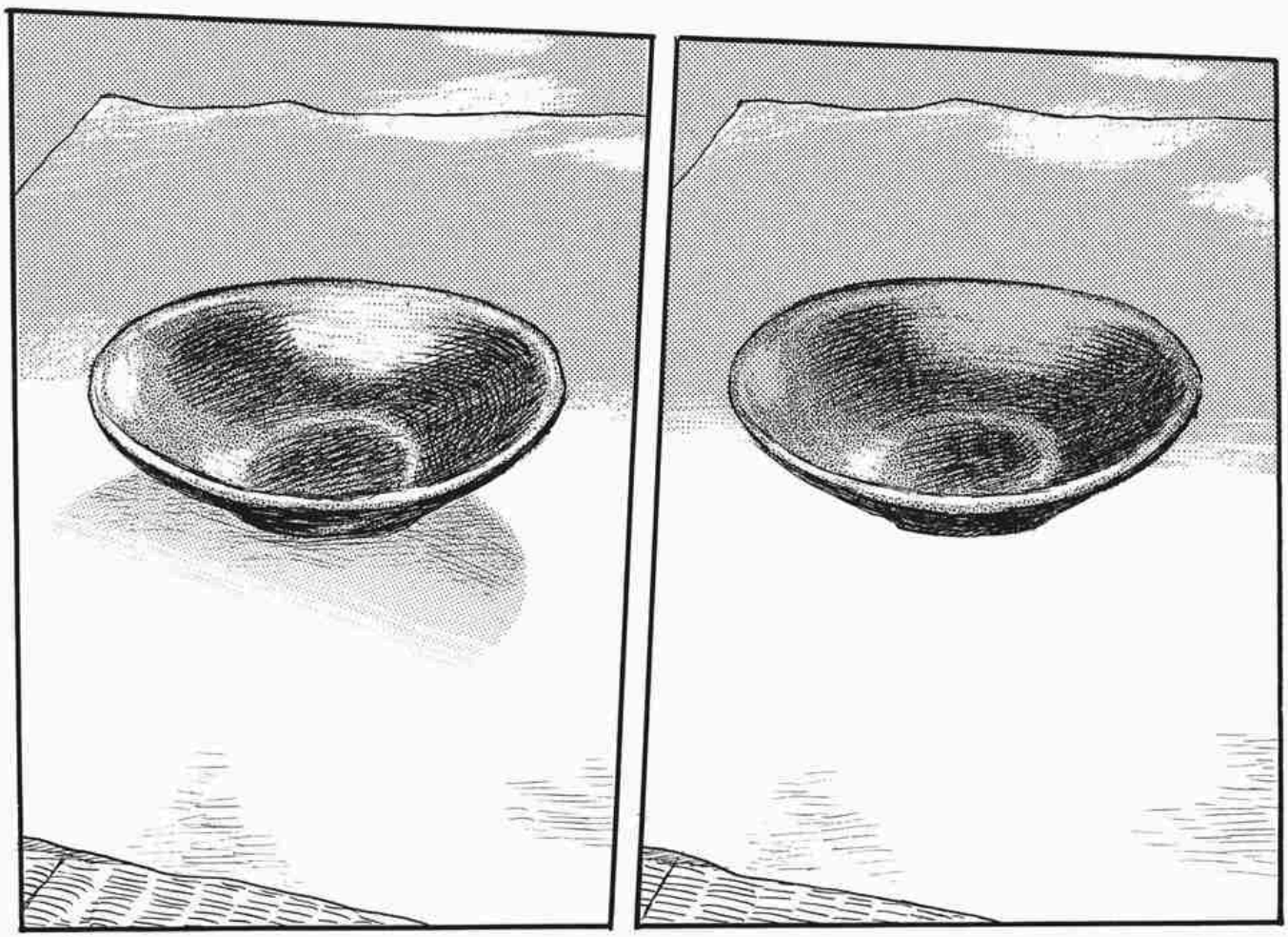

Your grandmother took almost no time to decide.
Will you lend her your power?
Shinra?
. . . I can actually meet Shinra?
. . . that if we do this. . .
Is it true. . .
What do you want to do?
. . . . . .
Really?


There are obstacles in the house...
...so let's do it out here.
Don't look at what I'm drawing!
I told you I wouldn't!
Okay, Shinra...
...you know that story of your grandmother and the mushi party I was telling you?
Draw the sake bowl that your grandmother received from the mushi.
Draw it with your left hand.


You should be able to.
My imagi-nation...
Huh? But...
I never heard what the color or shape of it was.
That's all right.
Draw it from your imagination.
つぷ
CH-THUP
He told me not to look, but I really have to.
Half of the bowl that your grandmother received...
...was inherited within the bodies of her child down to her grandchild.


じわ
SHLUP
Without even dipping it...
...the brush takes on its own color.
Green...
I get the feeling that's the color.
Just like...
...this country's greenery... A deep, vivid green.
And...


Flat...
...with a round shape.
That's the one!!
GRSSH




CHK
CHK
It's cracking.
Amazing!
PACHAK
Ah!
FUUU
ROLLL
Renzu...


ぱしん
PASHIN
.....
ガサ
FSSH
Is that...
...where she is?
Grandmother?
じわ
SHUWAA
かちん
KACHIK
I'll bring you two together.

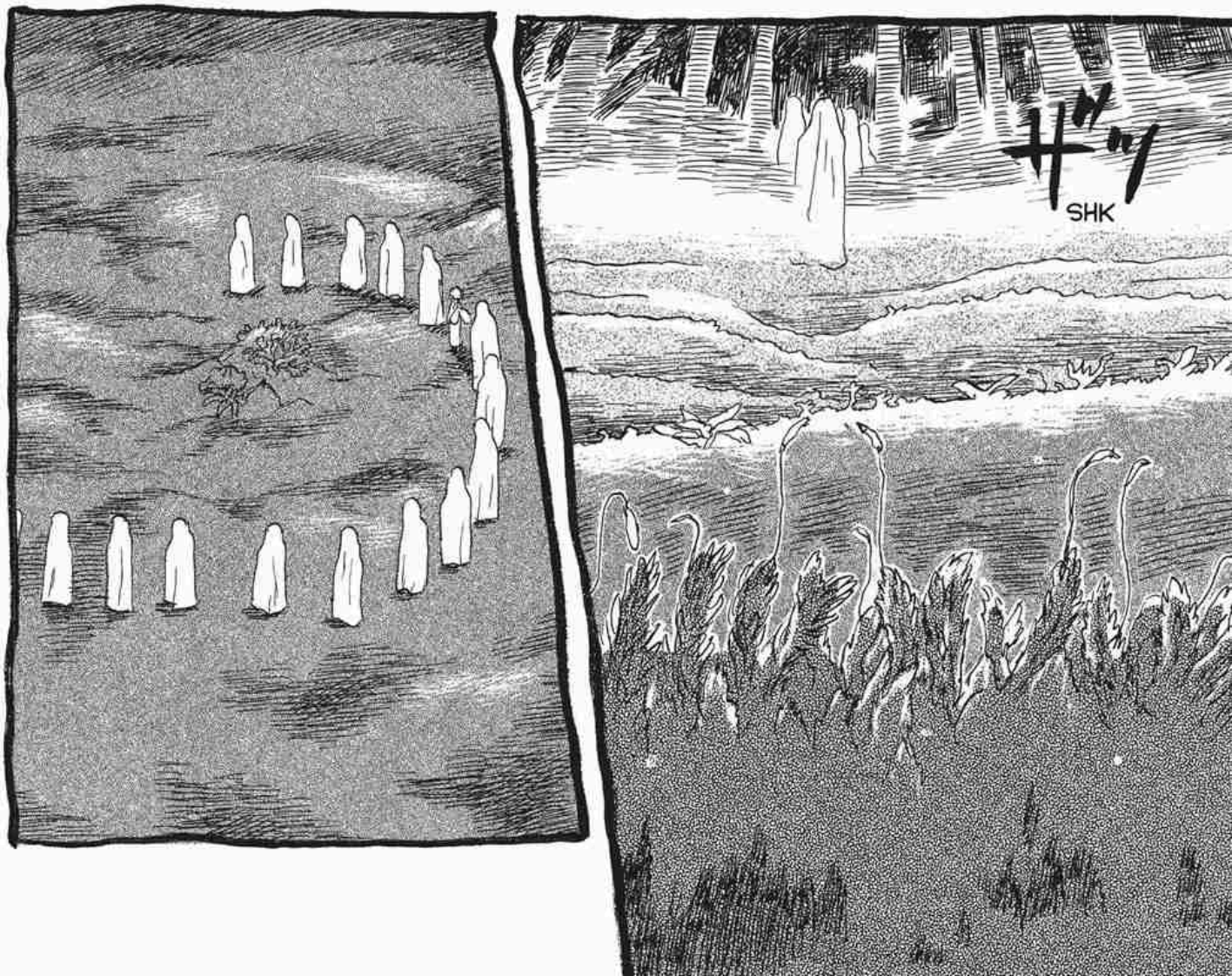

What is that...?
Now drink it down, Renzu.


Grand-mother...?
.....
.....
What are you two acting so embarrassed about?
Nothing, it's just that she's younger than I expected...


Here. Have some, too.
One in celebration.
.....?
Yes...
What's this...?
FLAP
FLAP
Are these grandmother's memories?
If I don't hurry up, the sun will set on me.

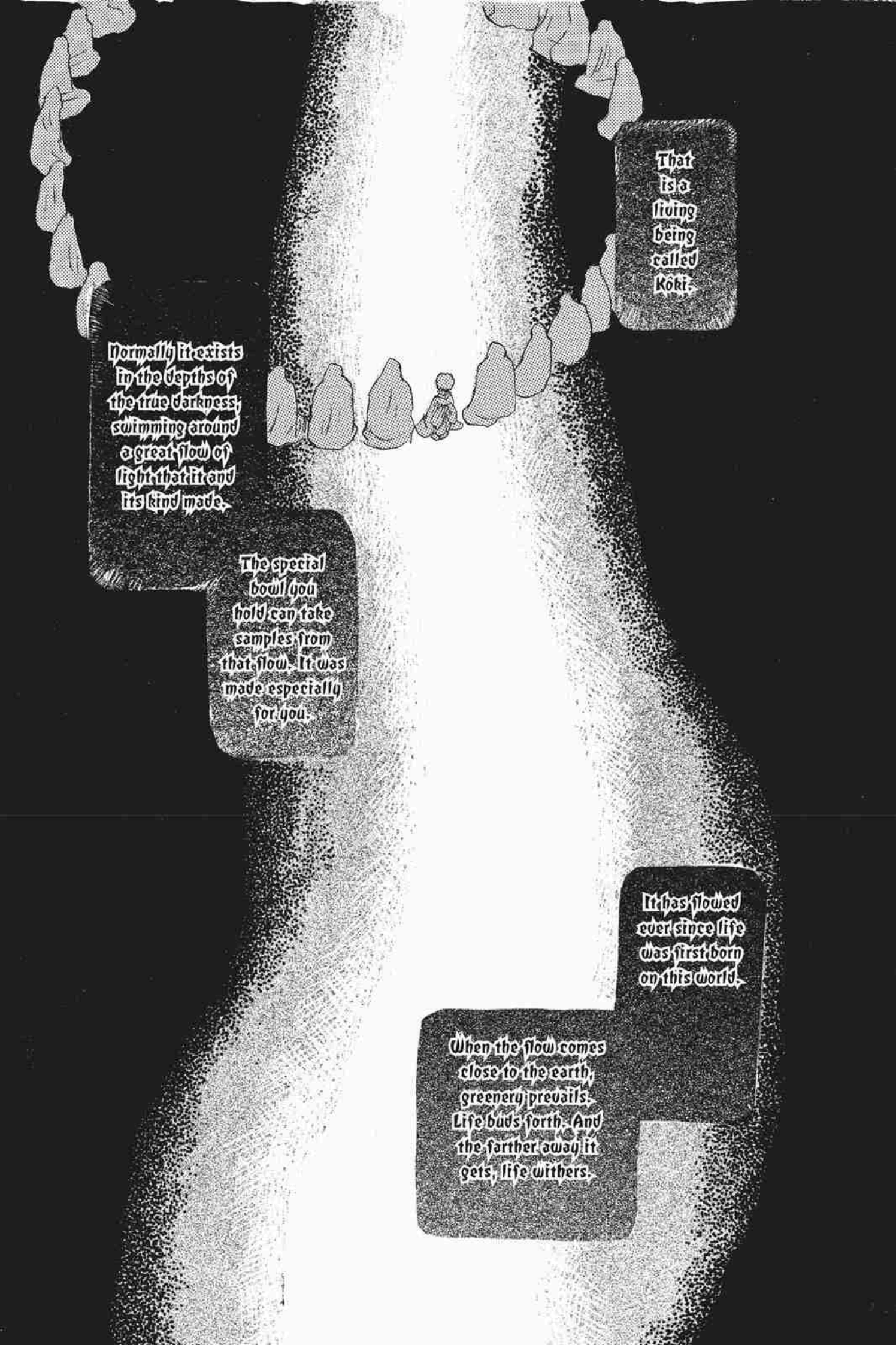

Mushi...?
SHK
SHK
SHK


I can't get out of the line.


SHK


SST
This gathering is all for you.
Drink it, Renzu Torii-dono.
Now drink it...


The fragrance is so sweet!
With just a single sip...
...I lose the strength to think.
Does it please you?

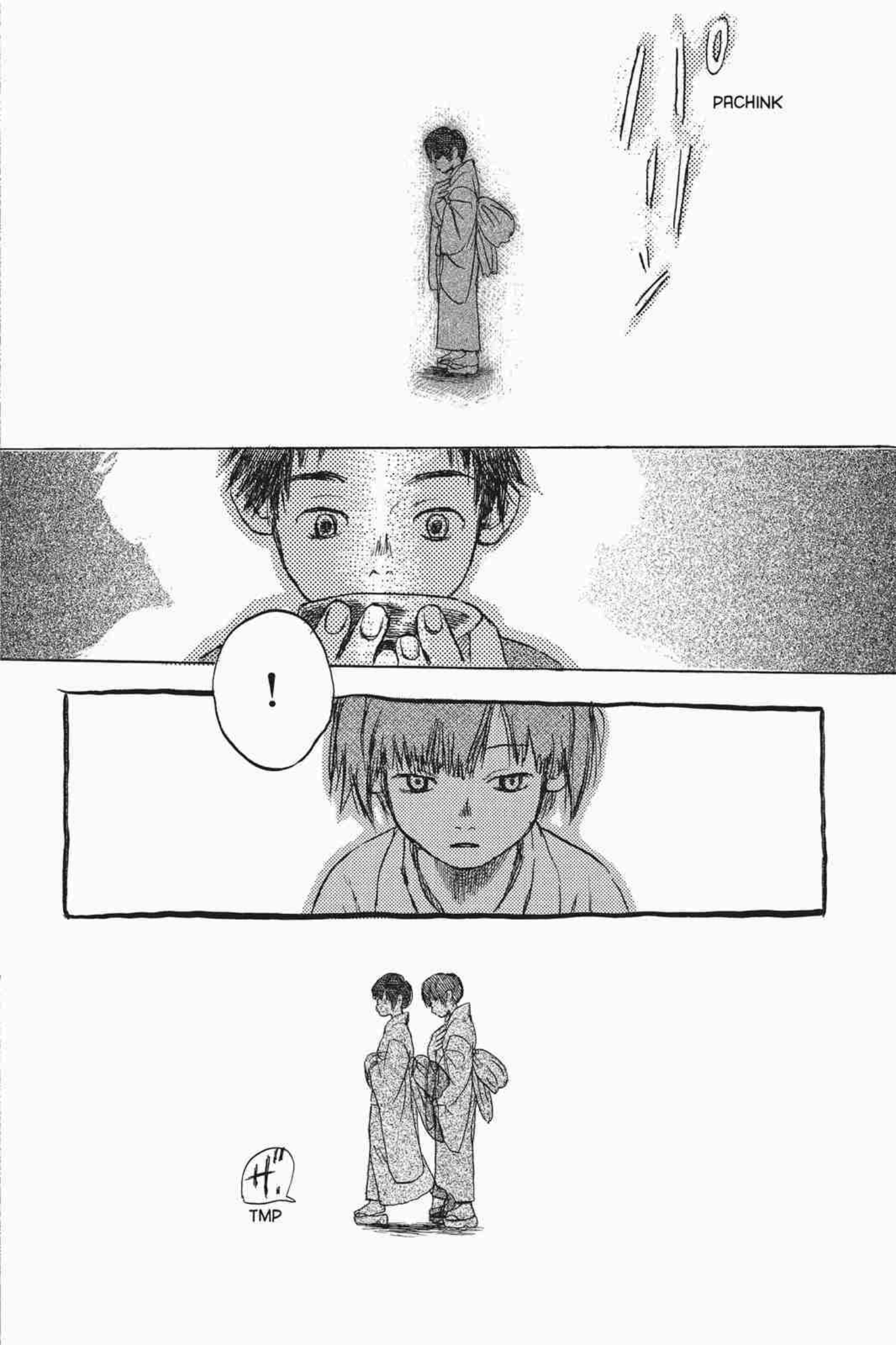

That is a living being called Kōki.
Normally it exists in the depths of the true darkness, swimming around a great flow of light that it and its kind made.
The special bowl you hold can take samples from that flow. It was made especially for you.
It has flowed ever since life was first born on this world.
When the flow comes close to the earth, greenery prevails. Life buds forth. And the farther away it gets, life withers.


Your grandchild, to be born thirty-one years from now...
...will possess a special ability with power enough to change the world of living beings.
Indeed. This is the water of life.
Nothing in this world is as delicious.
When placed in the drinking bowl, it becomes the greatest treat a person can have.
In exchange, we have a request to make of you.
We would have you watch over him for your lifetime.
My grandchild...?
If you do, then both that child and this world...
...will see true happiness.


If you wish for that as well...
...then please lend us your strength.
TSSP
And drink all of the sake that remains in that bowl.
FLAP
FLAP
KAWW


YUHFF
FLAPP
FUUU

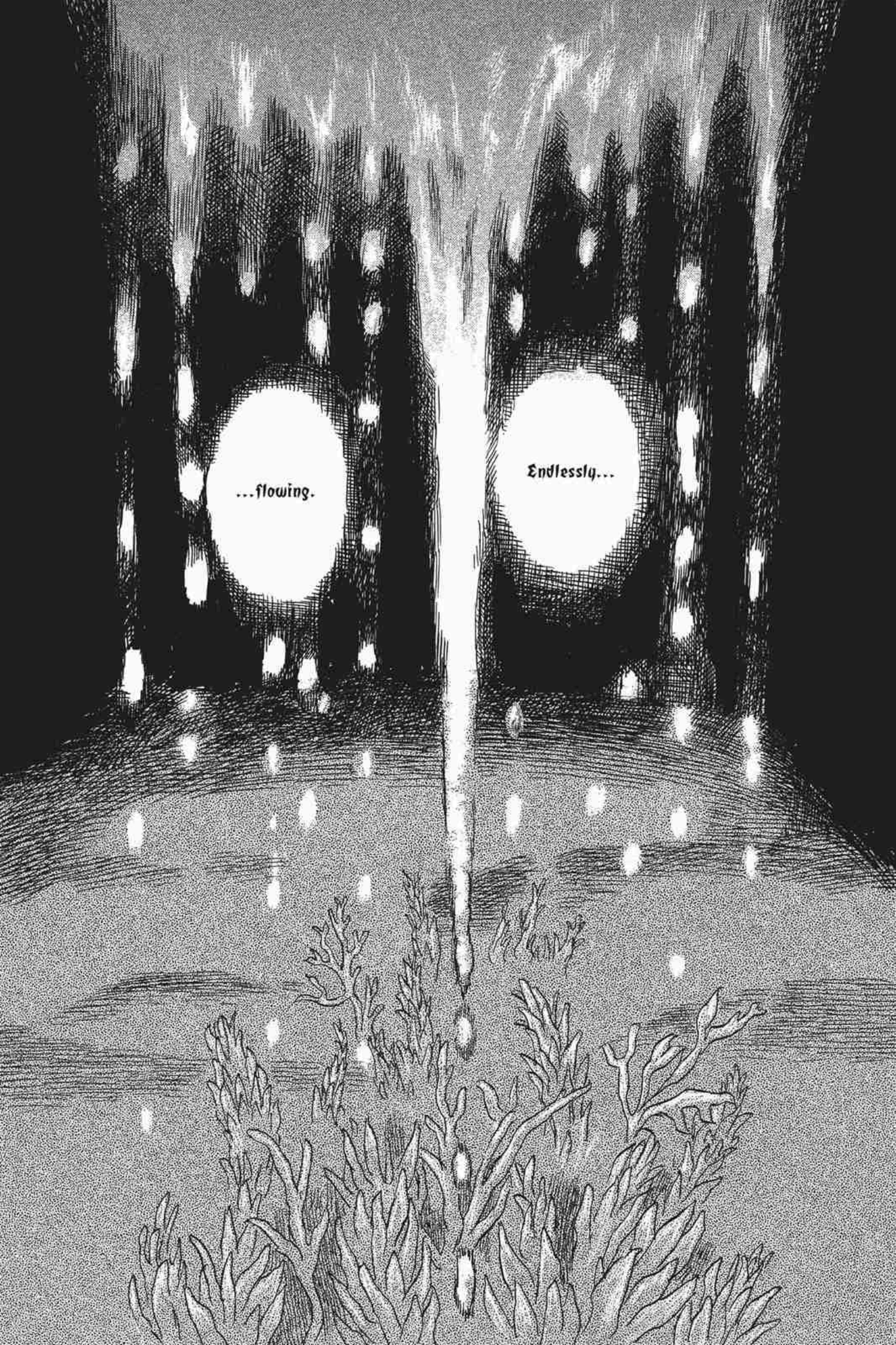

It's dried up.
FLAP
FLAP
I have to go home.


PACHINK
!
TMP


TMP
TMP
TMP
TMP
TMP
TMP
Shinra...?


Shinra's tears just kept flowing.
Renzu's emotions...and perceptions washed over him in minute detail.
It was just...
It was just...
...that the breaking of the drinking bowl was so sad, he couldn't help himself.
Oh?
I wonder what's come over me?


...the Kôki kept filling up the bowl.
And as if responding in sympathy...


...flowing.
Endlessly...


カ
ー
Z
Z
Z
Z
SHFF
Are you leaving already?


Amazing.
The whole thing's covered in moss.
Yes. Last night, the Kôki saturated the entire area.
Have you given up trying to investigate Shinra?
That's right.
There's this interfering guardian who's suddenly come back into his life.


I hate to say it, but Shinra will be lonely living on his own in a place like this.
Well, if your studies take you in this direction, then stop by again.
Ha ha!
...you're going to always be with him.
I doubt that'll be necessary.
From now on...
Huh?


Where's Ginko?
GWIP
He left already.
You mean without saying good-bye?
.....
Maybe, but unfortunately we don't have much to offer him by way of thanks.
Come to think of it.
I don't know about that.
See?



The Green Gathering The End